

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Ethics, Compliance and Professionalism

Introduction

This section will address the Ethics, compliance, and professionalism competence of the APM Project Management Qualification syllabus.

The training on this topic will enable you to gain an understanding of the different facets to be navigated and the need to work consistently in a moral, legal, and socially responsible manner.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

15. Understand ethics, compliance, and professionalism as the ability to work consistently in a moral, legal and socially responsible manner.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

15a) Understand the importance of continuing professional development, which should cover both knowledge, skills and behaviours, and the individual's role in identifying and addressing their own competence gaps.

15b) Knowledge of the sources of specialist advice and standards that need to be adhered to.

15c) Understand the impact of the legal and regulatory landscape on projects (such as the impact on working conditions, risk management, governance, and sustainability).

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Ethics, Compliance and Professionalism:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition, 3.3.4 (Regulatory environment); 3.3.5 (Ethics and standards); 3.3.6 (Continuing professional development)
- APM Learning Module, Ethics and Professionalism. Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/apm-learning/>
- APM The importance of ethics in professional life. Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/find-a-resource/thought-leadership/road-to-chartered-series/the-importance-of-ethics-in-professional-life/>
- APM Ethics in project management. Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/find-a-resource/ethics-in-project-management/>

Overview

Ethics, compliance and professionalism are integral aspects of effective project management:

- **Ethics:** Making morally sound decisions, ensuring transparency, and maintaining integrity throughout the life cycle of the project.
- **Compliance:** Ensuring adherence to laws and regulations and mitigating legal risks.
- **Professionalism:** Displaying competence, reliability and respect in interactions with all stakeholders.

Continuing Professional Development (CPD)

The project profession is navigated by a set of standards that articulates a defined level of technical knowledge, professional practice and ethical behaviour, ongoing continuing professional development (CPD) of your own competence enables you to demonstrate capability of those standards and the want to further develop them.



Continuing Professional Development (CPD) Cycle

This cyclical process involves ongoing learning and skill enhancement.

The CPD cycle typically includes:

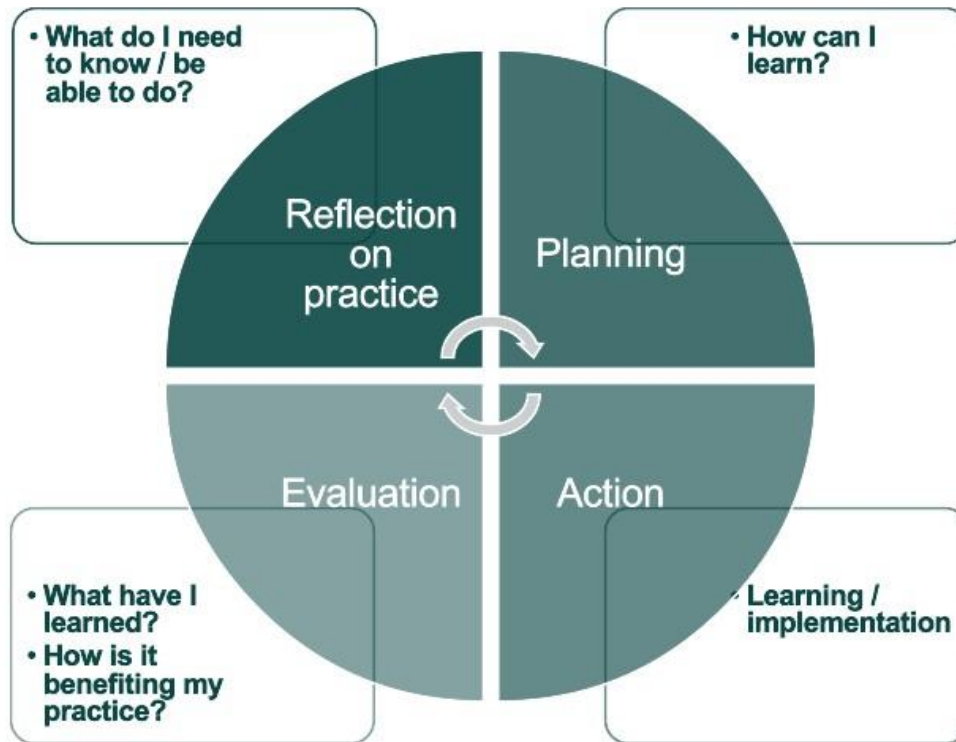


Figure 'CPD cycle' adapted from *Continuing Professional Development* by Andrew L. Friedman, Routledge, 2012, figure 1.2, copyright © Andrew L. Friedman, 2012. Reproduced with permission of Routledge via Copyright Clearance Center.

Specialist Advice and Standards

Trust and respect are vital to anyone who wants to be regarded as a professional. Trust is gained through consistently working in a moral, legal and socially responsible manner in accordance with organisational and professional codes of conduct.

Professionalism is a demonstratable awareness and application of competences and qualities, including knowledge and appropriate skills.

The APM FIVE Dimensions of Professionalism provides a framework to set standards and guide project professionals and includes:

- **Breadth**

APM Body of Knowledge defines the knowledge needed to manage any kind of project.

- **Depth**

APM Competence Framework maps levels of knowledge and experience to help progress skills and abilities.

- **Achievement**

APM recognised qualifications.

- **Commitment**

Continuing professional development (CPD) helps develop project management practice.

- **Accountability**

APM Code of Professional Conduct outlines ethical practice expected of a professional.

Where standards for ethical conduct are not being met, there is a duty as part of professional standards to report any wrongdoing.

Everybody has a responsibility to 'speak up', organisations are required to have a policy and process to enable individuals to 'speak up'.



Source: APM Body of Knowledge 7th edition (2019)

Legal and Regulatory Landscape

Projects operate within a legal and regulatory framework. This framework will be applicable to the industry and country where the work is being delivered.

Where the work is being delivered in different geographical locations, there may be conflicting regulations and standards to consider. The relevant governance structure decides which standards to align with.

Project professionals are responsible for understanding the regulatory environment they are operating within, if in doubt seek advice.

Regulations generally fall into two categories.

1. Advice set out with specific instructions that must be taken.
2. Advice set out that help employers set procedures where they can then decide how they control risks identified.

Failure to comply with regulations can result in advised corrective action through to custodial sentences for both individuals and the organisation.

Several project processes are influenced by the regulatory environment, including:

- Requirements capture
- Issue management
- Quality planning
- Change control
- Integrated planning
- Assurance arrangements
- Risk analysis and management



Scenario One:

The Snappy Appy renovation project is progressing to the point where materials have even begun to arrive onsite!

However, one of the block laying sub-contractors, who has done a lot of work in the local area, has come to you with a potential concern.

They have noticed that some of the materials that have arrived could be substandard – they don't have direct experience of using them but have heard that they can fail in some situations, which raises the possibility of safety concerns.

Ordering new materials will have an impact on an already tight delivery schedule and there is no first-hand evidence of any issues with the existing materials.

As the Project Manager, how would you navigate between the ethical obligation to prioritise safety and quality versus the pressure to meet the project's tight timeline and budget constraints?

Knowing that the sub-contractor's sources may be unreliable, what additional specialist advice could you look for and where from?

In your answer, you may want to consider laws, acts, regulations and regulatory bodies, international standards, organisational guidelines or governance, etc.

Scenario Two:

As more and more contractors and sub-contractors arrive onsite, you've noticed some concerning behaviour.

There seems to be inconsistency in instructions given leading to misunderstandings and delays with some of the construction elements.

Additionally, the sub-contractor's concerns and advice seem to be routinely dismissed which has led to a sometimes tense working environment onsite, which in turn appears to be not only slowing the project down, but also affecting onsite morale too.

What suggestions could you recommend or implement which would ensure that higher levels of professionalism were applied across the site?

If this lack of professionalism isn't addressed, which specific project processes could be affected and in what way/s?

Scenario Three

As a Project Manager leading the 'Snappy App' renovation, you recognise the need to ensure that your skills are kept current and that you're aware of advancements in the industry.

At the beginning of the project, you committed to using the Continuous Professional Development (CPD) cycle to ensure that this happened.

Using the CPD structure of Planning – Action – Evaluation – Reflection on Practice, how could you go about following this?

What are some examples of things that you could do as part of each phase of the CPD cycle?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Ethics, Professionalism and Compliance section:

- How can integrating ethical principles benefit project management outcomes?
- What is the significance of professionalism in project management and its impact on team dynamics?
- Why is it important to engage in a cyclical learning process like CPD?
- Why is 'reflection on practice' an essential component of the CPD cycle?
- What steps can be taken to ensure transparency and integrity in decision-making?
- How does ethical decision making contribute to building trust among project stakeholders?

Exam practice questions

15.1 As a practising project professional, you have realised the importance of continuous professional development (CPD) to maintain ethical standards and serve your clients effectively.

Which of the following best illustrates the significance of CPD in your profession?
(1 mark)

- a. CPD helps you avoid legal consequences by staying ahead of regulatory changes.
- b. CPD allows you to prioritise organisational interests over ethical considerations.
- c. CPD ensures your legal knowledge, skills, and ethical standards remain up-to-date.
- d. CPD re-distributes the responsibility of ethical conduct from the individual to the organisation.

15.2 You are a senior project manager working on a project to improve business operations. Within your project team, a number of junior team members have missed meetings with key stakeholders, and completed project documents to a poor standard.

Which three of these actions could help them to improve their professionalism, standards, and conduct as project professionals?
(1 mark)

- 1. Read the company's Code of Professional Conduct.
- 2. Speak with friends in other professions to learn how they act day-to-day.
- 3. Complete regular continual professional development (CPD).
- 4. Get a mentor from outside the company to help identify career opportunities.
- 5. Identify root cause of falling standards.
- 6. Ensure meetings are face-to-face to build rapport with key stakeholders.

Select one combination of answers:

- a. 1, 2, 5
- b. 1, 3, 4
- c. 2, 4, 6
- d. 1, 3, 5

15.3 You are sponsoring a project to build a pedestrian bridge.

A new regulation has been issued which states that large infrastructure projects must now meet a certain standard of sustainability.

Which response would be most appropriate in light of the new regulation?
(1 mark)

- a. Revisit the project business case to review the project schedule.
- b. Add to your risk register, to include any impact the regulation might have on your project.
- c. Try to get the project through its next stage gate quicker, so you won't be affected by the new regulation.
- d. All of the above.

15.4 All project-based work operates within a legal and regulatory framework relevant to the industry and countries where work is performed.

What are three project processes that the regulatory environment influences and what two things can you do as a Project Manager to stay up-to-date with the latest regulations?
(5 marks)

15.5 You are a project manager of a large infrastructure construction project at a charity. During the project, you encounter a situation where a potential subcontractor offers the charity a financial donation.

What are two sources of specialist advice or standards that you would rely on to guide how you would approach this situation?
(2 marks)

15.6 Continuing professional development (CPD) is the primary responsibility of the ____ (a) ____ to ensure competency gaps are identified, training plans are developed, and the achievement of learning is recorded.

The CPD cycle can support this activity – the steps include reflection on practice, planning, action and ____ (b) ____.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. Portfolio manager
2. Employer
3. Employee
4. Project sponsor

(b)

1. Evaluation
2. Implementation
3. Return on Investment
4. Consultation

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark scheme
15.1	C
15.2	D
15.3	B
15.4	1 mark for each correct process, 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Risk management. • Requirements capture. • Procurement. • Quality management. • Issue management. • Change control. • Assurance. 1 mark for each thing you can do to stay up-to-date, 2 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Relevant CPD (Continuing Professional Development). • Collaborating with industry experts/legal professionals. • Participate in forums. • Monitoring regulation updates regularly. • Sign up to newsletters from regulatory organisations. • Consult with experts within your organisation e.g. Company Secretary / Data Protection Officer.
15.5	1 mark for each source of advice or standard that would be applicable, 2 marks available in total. For example: • APM's Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct. • Speak with your project sponsor and seek advice on how best to progress. • Consult with legal experts / lawyers.. • Seek advice from industry-specific professional organisations. • Refer to relevant government regulatory bodies e.g. Charity Commission. • Consult organisational / industry standards e.g. the International Organisation for Standardisation (ISO).
15.6	(a) 3 (b) 1